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SCHOOL OF JOURNALISM AND COMMUNICATION



COMM-135-C

Communication and Public Speaking

Course Syllabus

Winter 2026

TABLE OF CONTENTS

COURSE DESCRIPTION.....	2
Learning Outcomes	2
Biblical Foundation	2
Biblical Foundation Course Concept Map.....	3
ACADEMIC SUPPORT.....	4
Student Success Services	4
Student Support Services.....	4
Learning Disabilities	4
Writing Center.....	4
Tutoring Center.....	4
ACADEMIC HONESTY.....	5
What is Plagiarism.....	5
Artificial Intelligence (AI).....	5
COURSE CONDUCT	6
eClass Course & Textbook Access.....	6
Communication.....	6
Technology Use: Phones, Tablets, Computers.....	7
Safe Learning Environment.....	7
Decorum.....	7
Sabbath Hours.....	7
INSTRUCTIONAL METHODOLOGIES	8
Reading	8
Quizzes, Assignments, and Activities	8
Listening and Peer Feedback	8
Speeches and Outlines.....	8
Feedback.....	9
Final Exam	9
ATTENDANCE & MAKE-UP WORK.....	10
Attendance.....	10
Missed or Late Work	11
Missed Speeches.....	11
Withdrawing From Class	12
COURSE EVALUATION	12
GRADING	12
Grading Scale	12
Accessing Grades	12
REQUIRED SPEECHES	13
INTRODUCTION SPEECH (0 pts) Time: 1:00-2:00 mins	13
NARRATIVE SPEECH (60 pts) Time: 3:00 – 4:00 mins	13
INFORMATIVE SPEECH (155 pts) Time: 5:00-6:00 mins.....	13
GROUP SPEECH (100 + 50 pts) Time: 15-20 mins per group.....	13
SPEECH TO ACTUATE (160 pts) Time: 7:00-8:00 mins	14
CRITERIA USED FOR EVALUATING SPEECHES.....	14
DISCLAIMER.....	14
Appendix A: Learning Outcomes within the Biblical Foundations Framework	15
Appendix B: TENTATIVE SCHEDULE OF ASSIGNMENTS	18



Winter 2026: January 12 – May 07, 2026
Time: MW 12:30 PM – 1:45 PM
Location: WSMS, 2nd floor (across from Brock Hall)
Instructor: Prof. Nataliia Irwin, MA, MS
Email: nirwin@southern.edu
Office Hours: MW 2 PM – 4 PM, School of Journalism and Communication, Brock Hall, Room 1015H
Other times are available by appointment (see *the “Communication”* section)
Textbook: **Wood, J. & Hains, R. (2024). Communication in our lives, 9th edition** (online via MindTap)
Platforms: eClass: eclass.e.southern.edu and MindTap (textbook through eClass)



COURSE DESCRIPTION

The Communication and Public Speaking course introduces students to the ways communication affects and relates to our everyday lives. Students will acquire theory and develop skills in preparing, presenting, and critically consuming messages in one-on-one, small group, and public speaking contexts.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this course, students should be able to:

- Learn foundational communication principles and processes;
- Demonstrate understanding of context and culture for communication in our daily lives;
- Plan, research, and organize material for ethical and effective presentations;
- Deliver effective public speeches;
- Demonstrate speaking and listening skills through critical evaluation of presentations.

For the learning outcomes (LOs) within the Biblical Foundation Framework, see the next section.

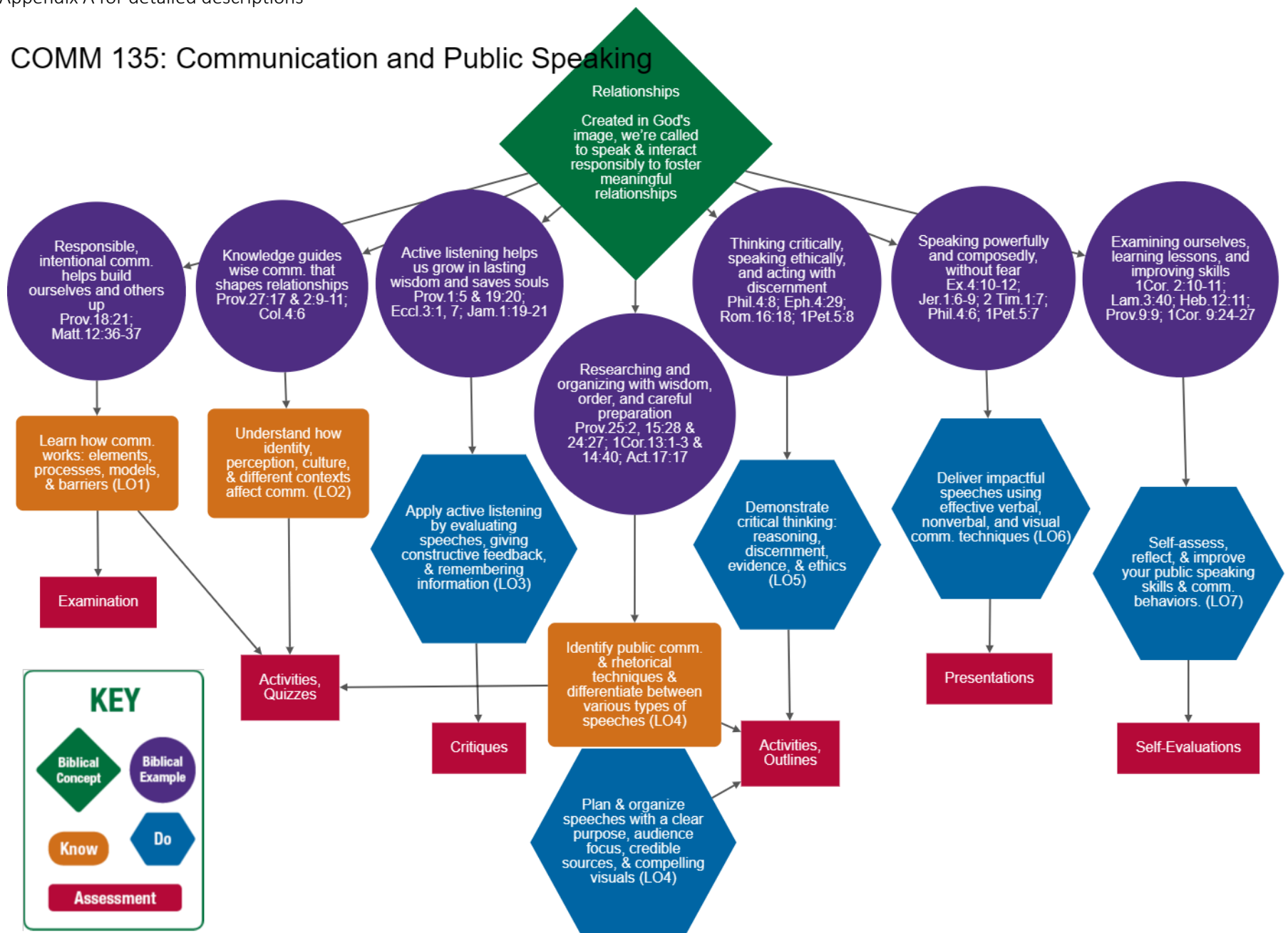
BIBLICAL FOUNDATION

When God created us in His image, He made us with a capacity that no other species on Earth was given – the ability to reason, discern, and express ourselves with voice and words. By refining these abilities, we can more nearly reflect His character, enhance our relationships with others, and make a significant contribution to our society, including the professional world. **We are responsible to God and one another to uphold honesty and trustworthiness in our decisions, actions, and communications.**

BIBLICAL FOUNDATION COURSE CONCEPT MAP

See Appendix A for detailed descriptions

COMM 135: Communication and Public Speaking



ACADEMIC SUPPORT

- eClass Help Desk:** Help with eClass, Panopto, Turnitin, digital textbook access in MindTap, etc. Email eclasshelp@southern.edu or call 423.236.2086.
- IT Help Desk:** Help with MyAccess, computer/tablet hardware and software, etc. Go to IT Workstation Support in Wright Hall (Same as the Campus Card Desk) or call 423.236.2712.
- Embedded Librarian:** Jessica Spears is an excellent resource for this class. Email jspears@southern.edu or call 423.236.2000.

STUDENT SUCCESS SERVICES

The [Student Success](#) team provides timely support to **students facing academic challenges**. Schedule personalized, one-on-one meetings with a specially trained academic support manager to get help with **stress and anxiety**, time management, **test-taking** tips, learning styles, and much more. Call 423-236-2838 to schedule an appointment or visit the Student Success office (Room 2126) in McKee Library.



STUDENT SUPPORT SERVICES

Student Support Services provides [individual counseling](#) to increase knowledge and develop greater self-awareness, understanding, and independence in areas such as depression, personal crises, self-esteem, loss and grief, family issues, anxiety, and much more.

[Life Calling and Career](#) provides information, thoughtful dialogue, and assistance as you consider your career path, including choosing a major, career exploration, resume building, interview preparation, etc.



LEARNING DISABILITIES

If you believe you may **need accommodations based on the impact of a disability or learning challenge** (i.e. physical, learning, psychological, ADHD, or other type), you are strongly encouraged to contact Disability Support Services (DSS) at 236-2574 or stop by the Bietz Center, 3rd floor, to arrange a confidential appointment. Specific details remain confidential between students and DSS.

If your **accommodation request is approved**, your professor(s) will receive an email containing the official *DSS Letter of Accommodation*. However, it is the student's responsibility to follow up with their professor(s) to discuss how these accommodations will be implemented. Accommodations are not retroactive to the discussion or course requirements completed prior to this meeting. For more details, visit the [DSS webpage](#).



WRITING CENTER

The Writing Center, located on the 3rd floor of McKee Library, provides support on all kinds of writing projects, including brainstorming as you start planning your speech, clarifying ideas, organizing your speech, strengthening content, citing sources correctly, etc. [Schedule an appointment](#) online or call 423.236.2014 for assistance.



TUTORING CENTER

The Tutoring Center, located on the 3rd floor of McKee Library, provides tutoring for more than 50 courses. Students can meet with a tutor to review course principles, learn content-specific study strategies, and enhance content area knowledge. [Schedule an appointment](#) online or call 423.236.2578 for assistance.



ACADEMIC HONESTY

Academic honesty (AH) is one of the essential values that enable Southern to function as a university that offers a Christian education.

All students who take this course are expected to adhere to the highest levels of **ethical integrity regarding research and submitted work**. Failure to adhere to this policy, also called **plagiarism**, constitutes a violation of the School's honor code regarding scholastic integrity. Such violations can result in disciplinary action as outlined in the procedures for handling academic dishonesty in the [Southern University Catalog](#).



Southern has contracted with [Turnitin](#), a company that provides resources for students and services for professors to check the originality of homework, assignments, projects, and speeches submitted for a grade. **Plagiarism is grounds for failing this course.**

WHAT IS PLAGIARISM

Plagiarism occurs when a student uses another person's words, phrasing, sentence structure, images, sounds, ideas, or any other component of intellectual expression and presents them as their own.

To maintain academic integrity and **avoid plagiarism**, it is essential for students to accurately and consistently give credit by citing the sources of others' ideas and expressions. Proper citation not only upholds scholarly standards but also demonstrates respect for intellectual property.

Students are expected to conduct their own research, write their own work, and properly cite their sources. Note that **paraphrasing** without proper citation constitutes plagiarism.

Submitting work, in whole or in part, that has been previously submitted for credit in another course or assignment constitutes **self-plagiarism** (if not disclosed ahead of time) and will result in disciplinary action. Students who use **speeches from previous students** or other sources may fail the course.



A guide that highlights the current state of plagiarism on college campuses and advises on how to detect and prevent plagiarism: [Plagiarism Prevention and Awareness Guide](#).

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE (AI)

Committed to Christian values, the use of AI tools in this course must align with principles of academic honesty, integrity, transparency, and responsible learning. As AI tools become more prevalent in academic and professional settings, this course will treat them as supportive resources – ***not substitutes for original thought, analysis, or personal learning***. Students are expected to submit work that ***reflects their own understanding and effort***.

By engaging with AI tools responsibly, you will **enhance your ability to navigate professional environments** where these technologies are becoming increasingly prevalent. Doing so allows us to develop all our gifts to the glory of God and to share and serve as members of a wider community.

| PERMITTED USES (UNLESS OTHERWISE SPECIFIED):

- Brainstorming ideas or outlines
- Practicing concepts or receiving feedback
- Exploring alternative explanations or approaches to concepts
- Editing grammar, syntax, or clarity in writing
- **If you use AI tools, you must briefly disclose how you used them in your assignment**

| PROHIBITED USES:

- Generating entire assignments, outlines, slideshows, speeches, etc.
- Submitting AI-generated content without meaningful revision or attribution
- Answering assignment, quiz, or exam questions
- Avoiding independent engagement with the course material
- Delivering AI-assisted speech without practicing or understanding the material
- Using AI to create research citations without verifying sources
- Relying on AI-generated examples or anecdotes without checking their accuracy or relevance

| STUDENT RESPONSIBILITY:

- Asking if unsure about acceptable AI use
- Always verifying the accuracy of any AI-generated content
- Disclosing use of AI tools
- Abiding by university-wide academic integrity standards.

Failure to disclose the use of an AI tool on any task will be considered an academic integrity infringement and will be penalized.

COURSE CONDUCT

ECLASS COURSE & TEXTBOOK ACCESS

The two essential learning platforms for this course are **eClass** and Cengage's **MindTap**, your textbook.

- **eClass** is your learning platform where you can find your grades, syllabus, resources, requirements for assignments, drop boxes for submitting assignments, grading rubrics, quizzes, and more. There are two ways to log in to your eClass. First, through the eClass link under the *Bookmarks* section on your MyAccess Dashboard. Second, by going directly to eClass: eclass.e.southern.edu (bookmark it for convenience).
- Your **textbook** is offered through Cengage's **MindTap** learning management system (MLS), also called inclusive access. To access your textbook, you need to log in to eClass, click on the speech class, and click the "*Read Textbook Here*" link or the button. You may need to register in Cengage if you are accessing MindTap for the first time; follow the prompts. The textbook offers various learning resources, including flashcards, sample presentations, an outline builder, and more – take the time to explore.

COMMUNICATION

OFFICE HOURS: Mondays and Wednesdays from 2:00 PM to 4:00 PM at the School of Journalism and Communication (Brock Hall, Room 1015H). Other times are available by appointment, including via Zoom or Teams. You must schedule an appointment by email; send your request to nirwin@southern.edu.

PRIMARY COMMUNICATION. To facilitate communication between the professor and students, make sure to check your Southern email at least once daily. This will be our primary communication outside of class. You can email questions, comments, concerns, and/or feedback about the class. I aim to respond within 24 hrs; however, please allow up to 48 hours for a reply, excluding weekends.

EMAILS. When sending an email, please include the name of your **course section in the subject line** (COMM-135-C; without the course title) and begin with a **formal greeting**. A proper salutation is expected of all University students. For example, you may begin your email with "Prof. Irwin" or "Good morning, Professor." I will not respond to emails that begin with "Hey" or omit a proper salutation, as it is important to develop habits of professional and respectful communication.

TEXT MESSAGING. Occasionally, I share important class updates using the Southern texting system. These messages are sent to the entire class; individual messages cannot be sent, and replies are not possible. To receive these updates via text, you must provide consent for **Non-Emergency** Text Messaging through MyAccess (at the bottom right of the MyAccess Dashboard). This is separate from the **Emergency** Text Message System (Omnilert). If you do not provide consent, the messages will be delivered to you by email instead.

TECHNOLOGY USE: PHONES, TABLETS, COMPUTERS

Computers, tablets, and smartphones will be used to access eClass, complete and submit assignments, take chapter quizzes, and perform other class-related tasks.

You will also use your phone/tablet to scan attendance QR codes. It is each student's responsibility to ensure their device records attendance accurately. If your device does not scan QR codes, visit IT Workstation Support.

During class, the use of devices – including computers, tablets, phones, headphones, and earbuds – is **prohibited** unless specifically authorized by the professor. Unauthorized use of devices may result in a reduced "Participation and Assignments" grade. Please ensure your **cell phone is set to silent** before putting it away.

SAFE LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

The classroom is a shared learning space. Thus, each student is expected to contribute to a class environment that promotes learning, dignity, respect, and professionalism. In consideration of others, please do not arrive late, speak at inappropriate times, sleep in class, take frequent breaks, engage in loud or distracting behavior, use cell phones or other devices for non-class-related purposes, or display disrespect toward others.

Communication should be clear, respectful, and free from slang, sarcasm, inappropriate jokes, and profanity. Students should practice active listening (part of the grade) and engage in discussions with a positive attitude, openness, and respect for differing viewpoints.

DECORUM

Students are expected to dress in a manner that reflects the values of our shared faith, emphasizing modesty, respect, cleanliness, neatness, and professional appropriateness – avoiding clothing that is overly tight or revealing. In accordance with the *Student Handbook*, the following attire is not permitted in class: tank tops, pajamas, loungewear, low-cut tops, bare midriffs or shoulders, exposed camisoles, miniskirts with or without leggings, and skirts with deep slits, sheer fabrics, torn, frayed, or clothing with printing that contradicts university standards; jewelry is not allowed, except for medical alert items and wedding bands. Hats must be removed while in class, unless worn for religious or medical reasons. **On presentation days, business attire is required.**

SABBATH HOURS

Southern affirms the Seventh-day Sabbath as a sacred time for rest, worship, and a break from academic pursuits. On our campus, the Sabbath is observed from sundown Friday to sundown Saturday each week. While we fully respect each student's personal beliefs and individual choices regarding worship, we ask that you honor the spirit of the Sabbath by refraining from studying and submitting assignments during these hours.

I gave them my Sabbaths, as a sign between me and them, that they might know that I am the Lord who sanctifies them. (Ezekiel 20:12).

INSTRUCTIONAL METHODOLOGIES

The course will consist of textbook readings, chapter reviews (no lectures), quizzes, discussions, different activities and exercises, speech planning, preparing outlines and slideshows (visual aids), and student presentations. Active participation as both a speaker and a listener is integral to the learning process, including providing and receiving feedback and completing self-critiques of your recorded speeches.

READING

Chapters from the textbook, as well as some additional reading, will be assigned regularly. Students are expected to complete all readings and come prepared to engage in class discussions and activities. Access to the textbook is available through eClass (see the *Course & Textbook Access* section above).

QUIZZES, ASSIGNMENTS, AND ACTIVITIES

Course quizzes and written assignments must be submitted electronically through eClass unless otherwise specified. Various activities, including discussions, peer feedback, one-minute essays, and pop-up knowledge checks, will be conducted during the class period.

You will take **one quiz per chapter** as noted on the schedule. Quizzes will open each Wednesday after class and close 30 minutes before the next class. You will have one attempt and 10 minutes to complete each quiz. At the end of the semester, I will drop two quizzes with the lowest grades.

If you experience **technical issues during an online quiz**, let me know immediately, and I will provide a paper version to be completed during the professor's open hours. Otherwise, the quiz will be considered missed/failed.

If you experience **difficulties uploading an assignment** to eClass, email it to me as soon as you complete it so that the submission date & time are recorded. However, all assignments must be submitted to eClass for grading; any assignments **emailed but not uploaded to eClass will not be graded**. Students are responsible for ensuring that all work is submitted as required.

Due dates and times will be indicated on 1) eClass, 2) major deadlines outlined in the course Schedule (see Appendix B), and 3) announced in class. Students are responsible for managing their time effectively to ensure all work is submitted on or before the specified deadlines.

LISTENING AND PEER FEEDBACK

Listening and following instructions are critical components of communication and play a significant role in your overall grade in this class.

Critiques of your peers' speeches play a crucial role in providing feedback to the speaker regarding the quality and effectiveness of their presentations, ultimately contributing to the learning process through mutual exchange. Therefore, active and consistent participation is essential to your success in this course.

Following instructions carefully is also a graded expectation, as it ensures you exercise your listening skills, understand assignments, participate appropriately, and engage effectively with class activities.

SPEECHES AND OUTLINES

Students will deliver a total of five (5) required speeches: one ungraded and four graded speeches. Each speech type is outlined in the *Required Speeches* section below. You will also deliver at least one devotional and one open mic speeches to help you get more comfortable with public speaking and communication.

SPEECHES should be the **product of original research and writing**. Using speech topics and research from other classes that were submitted for a grade constitutes self-plagiarism and is not allowed (in some instances, I can allow you to present on material you submitted in other classes, so please consult with me to obtain

approval). Using AI to write your speech without meaningful revision, attribution, understanding the material, and practicing is also not allowed. For details, see the *Academic Honesty* and *AI Policy* sections of this Syllabus.

Speeches will be **evaluated** with criteria that involve content, organization, and delivery. **Content** includes factors such as topic selection, clarity of purpose and thesis, use of supporting materials with proper APA citation, personal insight and creativity, and persuasive appeal (for the final presentation). **Organization** will be assessed by focusing on the logical flow of ideas, clarity, and effectiveness of transitions between sections, and how effectively the speech is introduced and concluded. **Delivery** encompasses language and style, proper oral citation of sources, composure, posture, gestures, and facial and vocal expressions.

Students are expected to **present on the assigned days**. You will have the opportunity to provide input during the scheduling process. Final schedules will be shared within the first couple of weeks of the semester.

You may switch presentation days with a classmate, but only within the same speech category (narrative, group, informative, or persuasive). Any other adjustments to the schedule will be considered only in the case of an excused absence (see the *Missed Speeches* section below).

DRESS AND Demeanor. Business attire is required for all graded presentations. It must comply with the dress and demeanor guidelines outlined in the “Decorum” section of this syllabus. You must also display an appropriate professional demeanor while delivering a speech (avoiding inappropriate jokes, slang, chewing gum, side conversations or sitting during a group presentation, etc.).

OUTLINES are required for every graded speech and must include a purpose statement, a reference list, and AI prompts used during preparation. Detailed outline guidelines are provided in the textbook and will be reviewed in class. Outlines are part of the total speech grade. All outlines must be uploaded to eClass for credit.

If you experience **technical difficulties** uploading your outline to eClass, you must email it to me immediately upon completion so that the **submission date and time are documented**. However, assignments must still be submitted to eClass for grading; work not submitted through eClass will not be graded. Students are responsible for ensuring all assignments are submitted on time. No late outlines are accepted.

WRITING, CITATION, AND REFERENCES must conform to APA standards in the outlines and slideshows and be properly cited orally throughout the presentation.

FEEDBACK

Throughout this course, you will receive regular feedback from the professor. Verbal feedback will be given immediately after presenting speeches, discussions, or other activities. I aim to grade speeches and outlines within two weeks after the last presenter in that speech round. Online quizzes are graded immediately after completion; I allow you to see the wrong and correct answers.

Your feedback about the class, learning environment, and my teaching style is just as important as the feedback you receive. I encourage you to speak up if you have suggestions, concerns, questions, or need more support with assignments. Please let me know what’s working well for you and what isn’t. Don’t wait until the end of the semester to share your thoughts. Early feedback allows for meaningful adjustments that can **benefit your learning experience right now** – not just for future classes.

FINAL EXAM

Final examinations will be administered according to the official Southern Exam Schedule, available at southern.edu/examschedule. All speech courses have a common exam period, rather than following the exam time assigned to the regular class meeting. This semester, the speech exam will be on **Monday, May 4, 2026, from 4:00 to 5:50 PM EST**. It will be in the form of an online quiz taken in a face-to-face setting. The classroom location will be announced in class and posted on eClass approximately one week prior to the exam date.

The **best study guides** for preparing for your final exam are the chapter quizzes, chapter outlines, and in-class PowerPoint lectures.

You will receive an **immediate grade upon completion of the exam**, but the overall course grade will be posted by the grades due date (check the Records department webpage southern.edu/records).

COMPUTER REQUIREMENTS. You must bring a computer that meets the required system specifications (most tablets and all cell phones do not meet the specs). Your device will be tested in class prior to the exam. It is each student's responsibility to ensure their device is available, operational, and ready for use.

If you encounter technical issues, contact eClass Helpdesk or borrow a computer from a friend. **Failure to bring a suitable computer is not a valid reason for rescheduling the final exam.**

RESCHEDULING THE EXAM. There are several approved reasons to reschedule your final exam:

- Illness verified by University Health Center or a physician;
- Death in the immediate family;
- Three examinations scheduled consecutively in one day, or four examinations scheduled in one day.

A final exam may be rescheduled only with the approval of both the professor and Dr. Dionne Felix, AVP for Academic Administration, by submitting the required form (scan the QR code). All non-emergency requests must be submitted to me at least one week prior to the start of the exam week. **Examinations rescheduled for any reason other than those listed above require a fee of \$100 per class.**



IF TESTING ACCOMMODATIONS LISTED IN THE DSS LOA:

Students who choose to use their DSS testing accommodations are responsible for coordinating arrangements with both the professor and the DSS office. Students must provide the professor with a completed proctoring form (scan the QR code) **at least 10 business days prior to the scheduled exam date**. The DSS-proctored exam must be scheduled in accordance with the official Southern exam schedule (see above).



ATTENDANCE & MAKE-UP WORK

ATTENDANCE

Attendance and active participation are critical to your success in this course. You are expected to attend every class session, arrive on time, and actively participate in discussions, speech critiques, activities, and other in-class assignments. It is your responsibility to review and fully understand all attendance and make-up policies.

Attendance and participation account for **30% of your final grade**. You must **earn at least 60%** of the available attendance points. Falling below this threshold will result in an automatic **one-letter reduction** of your final course grade, regardless of your performance in other categories.

Attendance will be recorded through **QR codes** using the Attendance Tracking System (ATS). **It is your responsibility** to ensure your device can scan QR codes and that your attendance is recorded accurately. If you experience technical issues, you must contact IT Workstation Support for assistance.

Absences will only be excused for illness with a valid doctor's note, **authorized school trips**, or **emergencies verified by Academic Administration** and/or your academic advisor. Excused absences are not penalized; however, students are responsible for the work they miss. It is your responsibility to initiate arrangements to make up any missed assignments. Excused absences are recorded in the ATS as 1/2 of the attendance points.

MISSED OR LATE WORK

If students miss a class for any reason, whether excused or unexcused, they are expected to review the material covered and ensure all assignments are completed by the deadline. **The professor is not responsible for "filling in" what students missed.** To stay on track, students are encouraged to talk to classmates for notes and updates on what was covered, check eClass, and the schedule in this syllabus.

| EXCUSED ABSENCES

Missing class(es) due to illness (with a valid doctor's note), authorized school trip, or emergency verified by Academic Administration and/or your academic advisor does not exempt you from completing assignments. If you must be absent, you are expected to notify me as soon as possible, preferably in advance. It is your responsibility to arrange and complete any missed assignments in a timely manner. Your grade will not be penalized.

| UNEXCUSED ABSENCES

In-class assignments missed due to unexcused absences are not eligible for make-up work.

| QUIZZES

Missed quizzes cannot be made up unless the absence is officially excused. However, I will drop two quizzes with the lowest grades at the end of the semester.

| SPEECH OUTLINES

No late speech outlines will be accepted (except for excused emergency situations). Expect your speech grade to drop if you present without an outline (grade value is about a 1/3 of the speech). For more details, refer to the *Instructional Methodologies/Speeches and Outlines* section.

| OTHER ASSIGNMENTS

The majority of the assignments are not eligible for late work, especially in-class work. However, some late work will be accepted up to one week after the original due date. All late submissions will receive a one-letter grade reduction, regardless of the number of days past the deadline the assignment is submitted.

MISSED SPEECHES

Students are expected to deliver their speeches on the assigned date. Presentation schedules will be provided in advance, so you must plan accordingly: consider any authorized school trips, intramurals, extracurricular commitments, departmental events, or other potential conflicts. You may **switch your presentation date with a classmate**, but this arrangement must be made at least one class period before your scheduled speech and communicated to me immediately. Below is the make-up policy for missed speeches:

- **UNEXCUSED ABSENCES: No make-up speeches will be available.**
- **APPROVED EMERGENCY**: I will make every effort to reschedule your presentation during regular class time; however, a **make-up opportunity is not guaranteed**. If no class time is available, you may be permitted to present to a panel of several speech professors instead of receiving a failing grade. It is the **student's responsibility to request this option as early as possible** so that arrangements can be made – note that this process depends on faculty availability.
- **UNIVERSITY-SPONSORED TRIP/EVENT**: If you miss your speech because you did not make prior arrangements, such as switching the date with a peer ahead of time, the same make-up conditions as emergency situations apply, with an additional 20% grade reduction penalty. In-class work that involves group activities will not have opportunities for make-up.

WITHDRAWING FROM CLASS

If you are at risk of failing the course because you stopped attending class or are not completing assignments, you may choose to withdraw from the course to avoid receiving a failing grade (F) on your transcript and negatively affecting your GPA. Refer to the Course Schedule myaccess.southern.edu/apps/courseschedule2 for the last day to withdraw and receive a “W” grade – the date is listed as the “**Last day to drop.**”

COURSE EVALUATION

Course evaluations are essential to Southern’s ongoing effort to enhance course delivery and maintain high academic standards, and your participation is strongly encouraged. An **extra credit** will be given for its completion. All comments and evaluations are **completely anonymous**.

Near the end of the semester, when Course Evaluation opens, you will see a **blue bar under the header** on the main page of your eClass. Click the bar and follow the prompts. You may also access the evaluation from your MyAccess account. Click the *Academics* tab, select *Course Evaluation*, and follow the prompts. Here is a direct link: <https://myaccess.southern.edu/mvc/courseevaluation>.

GRADING

No assignments will be graded unless they are uploaded to eClass. Grading rubrics will be provided along with the assignments on eClass. Grades are determined by the following criteria:

Category	Weight
Speeches (<i>speeches, outlines, PowerPoints</i>)	50%
Participation and Assignments (<i>attendance, discussions, critiques, activities, assignments, assessments, etc.</i>)	30%
Textbook Quizzes	10%
Final Exam	10%

GRADING SCALE

Grade	Score
A	93-100%
A-	90-92.9%
B+	87-89.9%
B	83-86.9%

Grade	Score
B-	80-82.9%
C+	77-79.9%
C	73-76.9%
C-	70-72.9%

Grade	Score
D+	67-69.9%
D	63-66.9%
D-	60-62.9%
F	0-59.9%

ACCESSING GRADES

You can access your grades by navigating to the *Grades* tab in your eClass navigation menu located directly below the course header on the main course page. The *Grades* section provides an overview of the grades you have earned so far in the course. You can also access your grades by clicking on individual assignments or submissions. Any feedback from the professor will be included in the respective assignments.

REQUIRED SPEECHES

You will present five (5) total speeches: four (4) individual and one (1) group speech. Each speech will weigh differently according to its level of difficulty and requirements. Below are brief descriptions of the required speeches you must present. The detailed requirements will be posted to eClass and distributed in class.

INTRODUCTION SPEECH (0 PTS – WARM-UP) | TIME: 1:00-2:00 MINS

This informal, ungraded speech is your first opportunity to be in front of the class. You will interview one of your classmates and introduce him/her to the class. Get as many details as possible to understand who your classmate is. Go beyond basic information and find an interesting angle to capture your audience's attention.

No outline is required. However, organize your facts and ideas, outline the speech, think about how to present it in an interesting way, and practice delivery. Practice but do not memorize your speech - this style of speech is called extemporaneous. Write your notes on a 4 x 6 index card or half a sheet.

NARRATIVE SPEECH (60 PTS) | TIME: 3:00 – 4:00 MINS

This is a “Compelling Story” speech – personal experience with a purpose. It allows you to exercise and sharpen your storytelling skills. Think of your experience that made a significant impact on your life. It may have been frightening, inspiring, embarrassing, funny, etc. Write in the first person and from your perspective, preparing the speech with vivid details and strong verbs to capture your audience's attention. Describe the context (time, location, surroundings, etc.), twists and turns that led to the situation (problems, challenges, feelings, etc.), the climax or anti-climax (powerful final point), and impact on your life (lessons you learned). Conclude by applying a principle or purpose to your story.

A key-word outline is required. This should not be a spontaneous account, but one you have planned for effective delivery and practiced (extemporaneous). Use 4 x 6 index cards or half-sheets for notes.

INFORMATIVE SPEECH (155 PTS) | TIME: 5:00-6:00 MINS

This is an individual **research presentation** aimed to inform, educate, or increase your audience's understanding of the significance of your specific topic. Its primary goal is to convey factual, objective information in a clear and engaging manner (not to persuade your audience). Choose a topic that interests you and your peers. Research the topic and utilize facts, figures, and statistics to educate your listeners. Make sure to present it with your unique perspective rather than just a straightforward textbook approach. The speech must be dynamic and informative, use well-prepared supportive materials, and orally cite sources used.

A formal speech outline and PowerPoint are required. Delivery is extemporaneous; use 4 x 6 index cards or half-sheets for notes.

GROUP SPEECH (100 + 50 PTS) | TIME: 15-20 MINS PER GROUP

This is a group informative speech. The class will be divided into groups, and each group will select one textbook chapter from the provided list. Each group will prepare an informative speech that highlights the importance of applying the communication principles covered in the selected chapter. Each group member will be responsible for researching and developing their own portion of the topic. While each section will be individually prepared, the final presentation must flow seamlessly and cohesively from one speaker to the next, maintaining logical continuity from start to finish and adhering to all principles of delivering an effective informative speech. The speech must be engaging and dynamic, supported by thoroughly researched and relevant materials, including sources beyond the textbook that are orally cited.

A formal speech outline and PowerPoint are required. Delivery is extemporaneous; use 4 x 6 index cards or half-sheets for notes.

PERSUASIVE SPEECH TO ACTUATE (160 PTS) | TIME: 7:00-8:00 MINS

Speech to Actuate is a persuasive speech that uses the 5 steps of Monroe's Motivated Sequence (MMS) as an outline to bring the audience to action. This is a final speech, so students will need to demonstrate all they have learned so far:

- Research, collect, organize, and present reliable information based on credible sources
- Properly cite sources throughout the speech to strengthen credibility and support arguments
- Practice effective and dynamic storytelling and persuasion, balancing Ethos, Logos, and Pathos
- Design eye-catching and effective visual aids that enhance presentations
- Transform the speech into an experience

You might try to convince your audience to sign a petition on some public policy matter, join a particular volunteer organization, take the first step toward starting a new habit, etc. Whatever your topic, don't treat it as a general list of advice points; focus on a specific action you want your audience to take.

A formal MMS outline and PowerPoint are required. Delivery is extemporaneous; use 4 x 6 index cards or half-sheets for notes.

CRITERIA USED FOR EVALUATING SPEECHES

AVERAGE SPEECH (GRADE C) CRITERIA:

1. Conform to the kind of speech assigned (informative, persuasive, etc.)
2. Be ready for the presentation on the assigned date
3. Conform to the time limit
4. Fulfill any special requirements of the assignment, such as preparing an outline, using visual aids, conducting an interview, etc.
5. Have a clear specific purpose and central idea
6. Have an identifiable introduction, body, and conclusion
7. Show reasonable directness and competence in delivery
8. Be free of serious errors in grammar, pronunciation, and word usage

ABOVE-AVERAGE SPEECH (GRADE B) SHOULD MEET THE PRECEDING CRITERIA AND ALSO:

1. Deal with a challenging topic
2. Fulfill all major functions of a speech introduction and conclusion
3. Display clear organization of main points and supporting materials
4. Support main points with evidence that meets the tests of accuracy, relevance, objectivity, & sufficiency
5. Exhibit proficient use of connectives—transitions, internal previews, internal summaries, & signposts
6. Be delivered skillfully enough so as not to distract attention from the speaker's message

EXCELLENT SPEECH (GRADE A) SHOULD MEET ALL THE PRECEDING CRITERIA AND ALSO:

1. Constitute a genuine contribution by the speaker to the knowledge or beliefs of the audience
2. Sustain positive interest, feeling, and/or commitment among the audience
3. Contain elements of vividness and special interest in the use of language
4. Be delivered in a fluent, polished manner that strengthens the impact of the speaker's message.

DISCLAIMER

As a Professor, I reserve the right to modify, supplement, and make changes to the course syllabus as needs arise. Students will be notified in writing (in eClass) and in class if/when any changes are made.

Appendix A

LEARNING OUTCOMES WITHIN THE BIBLICAL FOUNDATIONS FRAMEWORK

Course Biblical Concept: **RELATIONSHIPS** (*with God, self, and others*)

Created in God's image, we are called to speak and interact responsibly to foster meaningful relationships.

Bible Verses	Learning Outcome Description (LOs)
LO1: Learn how communication works: elements, processes, models, and barriers.	
<i>Responsible, intentional communication helps build ourselves and others up</i> ▪ Death and life are in the power of the tongue: and they that love it shall eat its fruit. (Prov. 18:21) ▪ On the day of judgment people will give account for every careless word they speak, for by your words you will be justified, and by your words you will be condemned. (Matt. 12:36-37)	Define and explain the basic elements and process of human communication, foundational communication concepts and models.
LO2: Understand how identity, perception, culture, & different contexts affect communication.	
<i>Knowledge guides wise communication that shapes relationships</i> ▪ Iron sharpens iron, and one man sharpens another. (Prov. 27:17) ▪ Let your speech always be gracious, seasoned with salt, so that you may know how you ought to answer each person. (Col. 4:6) ▪ Then you will understand righteousness and justice and equity, every good path; for wisdom will come into your heart, and knowledge will be pleasant to your soul; discretion will watch over you, understanding will guard you. (Prov. 2:9-11)	Demonstrate understanding of how identity, perception, verbal/nonverbal factors, and culture influence communication, and recognize and adapt to different communication contexts—interpersonal, group, organizational, and media.
LO3: Apply active listening by evaluating speeches, giving constructive feedback, & remembering information.	
<i>Active listening helps grow in lasting wisdom and saves souls</i> ▪ Let the wise hear and increase in learning, and the one who understands obtain guidance. (Prov. 1:5) ▪ Listen to advice and accept instruction, that you may gain wisdom in the future. (Prov. 19:20) ▪ For everything there is a season, and a time for every matter under heaven [...] a time to keep silence, and a time to speak. (Eccl. 3:1, 7) ▪ Let every person be quick to hear, slow to speak, slow to anger; [...] and receive with meekness the implanted word, which is able to save your souls. (James 1:19-21)	Apply active listening by receiving, organizing, interpreting, and evaluating messages, providing constructive feedback, minimizing listening barriers, and retaining information.

LO4: Plan and organize speeches with a clear purpose, audience focus, credible sources, & compelling visuals.	
Researching and organizing with wisdom, order, and careful preparation - It is the glory of God to conceal things, but the glory of kings is to search things out. (Prov. 25:2) <i>[Research]</i> - If I speak in the tongues of men and of angels, but have not love, I am a noisy gong or a clanging cymbal. (1 Cor. 13:1-3) <i>[Goodwill]</i> - So he reasoned in the synagogue with the Jews and the devout persons, and in the marketplace every day with those who happened to be there. (Acts 17:17) <i>[Audience]</i> - But all things should be done decently and in order. (1 Corinthians 14:40) <i>[Content & Organization]</i> - The heart of the righteous ponders how to answer, but the mouth of the wicked pours out evil things. (Prov. 15:28) <i>[Thoughtfulness]</i> - Prepare your work outside; get everything ready for yourself in the field, and after that build your house. (Prov. 24:27) <i>[Organization & Preparation]</i>	Identify public communication and rhetorical techniques and differentiate between various types of speeches. Identify and explain public communication techniques and plan, organize, and design speeches with clear structure, purpose, and audience analysis; support ideas using credible sources and ethical citation practices; and incorporate appropriate visual aids.
LO5: Demonstrate critical thinking: reasoning, discernment, evidence, & ethics.	
Thinking critically, speaking ethically, and acting with discernment - Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just, whatever is pure...think about these things. (Phil. 4:8) - Let no corrupting talk come out of your mouths, but only such as is good for building up, as fits the occasion, that it may give grace to those who hear. (Eph. 4:29) - By smooth talk and flattery they deceive the hearts of the naive. (Rom. 16:18) - Be sober-minded; be watchful. (1 Pet. 5:8)	Demonstrate critical thinking by evaluating messages for reasoning, evidence, and potential bias, while upholding discernment and ethical and culturally sensitive communication practices.
LO6: Deliver impactful speeches using effective verbal, nonverbal, and visual communication techniques.	
Speaking powerfully and composedly, without fear - But Moses said to the Lord, "Oh, my Lord, I am not eloquent, either in the past or since you have spoken to your servant, but I am slow of speech and of tongue." Then the Lord said to him, "Who has made man's mouth? Who makes him mute, or deaf, or seeing, or blind? Is it not I, the Lord? Now therefore go, and <u>I will be with your mouth and teach you what you shall speak</u>." (Exod. 4:10-12) - I said, "Ah, Lord God! Behold, I do not know how to speak, for I am only a youth." But the Lord said to me, "Do not say, 'I am only a youth'; for to all to whom I send you, you shall go, and whatever I command you, <u>you shall speak</u>." (Jer. 1:6-9)	Powerfully present various types of speeches using effective verbal, nonverbal, and visual communication techniques.

▪ For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control. (2 Tim. 1:7) ▪ Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. (Phil. 4:6) ▪ Casting all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you. (1 Pet. 5:7)	
LO7: Self-assess, reflect, and improve your public speaking skills and communication behavior.	
<i>Examine yourself, learn your lessons, and improve</i> ▪ For the Spirit searches everything, even the depths of God. (1 Cor. 2:10–11) ▪ Let us test and examine our ways, and return to the Lord! (Lam. 3:40) ▪ For the moment all discipline seems painful rather than pleasant, but later it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it. (Heb. 12:11) ▪ Give instruction to a wise man, and he will be still wiser; teach a righteous man, and he will increase in learning. (Prov. 9:9) ▪ All the runners run, but only one receives the prize? So run that you may obtain it. [...] So <u>I do not run aimlessly</u>; I do not box as one beating the air. But <u>I discipline my body and keep it under control</u>, lest after preaching to others I myself should be disqualified. (1 Cor. 9:24-27) ▪ Examine yourselves, to see whether you are in the faith. Test yourselves. Or do you not realize this about yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you?—unless indeed you fail to meet the test! (2 Cor. 13:5)	Recognize, assess, and improve your own speaking behavior while communicating in public by reflecting on performance, applying strategies to manage communication anxiety and composure, and building speaking confidence.
<i>Using talents purposefully</i> ▪ We have different gifts, according to the grace given to each of us. If your gift is prophesying, then prophesy in accordance with your faith; if it is serving, then serve; if it is teaching, then teach; if it is to encourage, then give encouragement; if it is giving, then give generously; if it is to lead, do it diligently; if it is to show mercy, do it cheerfully. (Rom. 12:6-8)	

Appendix B

TENTATIVE SCHEDULE OF ASSIGNMENTS

(This schedule may be adjusted if needed – Winter 2026)

	Day	Date	In Class	Assignments Due Before Class Begins (additional work will be assigned in class)
W1	Mon	01/12	- Orientation and Syllabus - Devotionals & Introductions schedule - Apprehension/PRCA Pre-Test - Discuss the Introduction Speech assignment	- Read Ch. 1 for Wed - Syllabus quiz due Wed, 01/21 - Work on your introductions
	Wed	01/14	Introduction Speeches (1-2 mins)	- Quiz Ch. 1: The World of Communication - Read Ch. 2 for Mon
W2	Mon	01/19	MLK COMMUNITY SERVICE DAY – NO CLASS	- Quiz Ch. 2: Perception & Comm. due @11:59 pm - Read Ch. 3 for Wed
	Wed	01/21	- Chapters 1-3 recap and in-class activities - Groups schedule - Discuss Narrative Speech assignment & activity	- Quiz Ch. 3: Comm. and Personal Identity - Syllabus Quiz - Read Ch. 12 for Mon
W3	Mon	01/26	Chapter recap and in-class activities	- Quiz Ch. 12: Planning Public Speaking - Read Ch. 14 for Wed
	Wed	01/28	Chapter recap and in-class activities	- Quiz Ch. 14: Organizing & Presenting Speeches - Read Ch. 15 for Mon, 02/09
W4	Mon	02/02	Narrative Speeches (3-4 mins) - Day 1	- All Narrative Speech Key-Word Outlines - Work on speech self-evaluations
	Wed	02/04	Narrative Speeches (3-4 mins) - Day 2	- Read Ch. 15 for Mon - Work on speech self-evaluations
W5	Mon	02/09	- Chapter recap and in-class activities - Discuss Informative Speech assignment & peer critiques - Writing for the ear - Pick a topic	- All Narrative Speech Self-Evaluations due - Quiz Ch. 15: Informative Speaking - Read Ch. 13 for Wed
	Wed	02/11	- Chapter recap and in-class activities - Plagiarism, APA format + Certificate	- Claim your topic on Forum - Quiz Ch. 13: Research & Support for Speeches - Read Ch. 4 for Mon
W6	Mon	02/16	- Chapter recap and in-class activities - Oral citations + Quiz - Writing Workshop	- Plagiarism Certificate - Bring your Purpose, Thesis, Preview to class - Quiz Ch. 4 Quiz: Listening Effectively - Read Ch. 5 for Wed
	Wed	02/18	- Chapter recap and in-class activities - Visual aids	Quiz Ch. 5: Verbal Dimension of Comm.
W7	Mon	02/23	Informative Speech (5-6 mins) - Day 1 (upload PPT)	- Oral Citations Quiz - All Informative Speech Formal Outlines - Work on speech self-evaluations
	Wed	02/25	Informative Speech (5-6 mins) - Day 2 (upload PPT)	Work on speech self-evaluations
W8	Mon	03/02	Informative Speech (5-6 mins) - Day 3 (upload PPT)	Work on speech self-evaluations
	Wed	03/04	Informative Speech (5-6 mins) - Day 4 (upload PPT)	- Work on speech self-evaluations - Read Ch. 8 for Mon
W9	Mon	03/09	- Chapter recap and in-class activities - Discuss Group Speech assignment/workshop	- All Informative Speech Self-Evaluations due - Quiz Ch. 8: Comm. in Groups and Teams - Read Ch. 6 for Wed
	Wed	03/11	Chapter recap and in-class activities	- Quiz Ch. 6: Nonverbal Dimension of Comm. - Read Ch. 16 for Mon, 03/23
W10	Mar	13-22	SPRING BREAK – NO CLASSES	

	Day	Date	In Class	Assignments Due Before Class Begins (additional work will be assigned in class)
W11	Mon	03/23	- Chapter recap and in-class activities - Group Speech Workshop	- Quiz Ch. 16: Persuasive Speaking - Read Ch. 7 for Wed
	Wed	03/25	- Discuss Speech to Actuate assignment - Monroe's Motivated Sequence (MMS) - Pick a topic	- Quiz Ch. 7: Comm. in Personal Relationships - Read Ch. 9 for Mon
	Thu	03/26	Last Day to Withdraw and Receive a "W" Grade	
W12	Mon	03/30	Group Speech - Day 1 (Upload PPT): Ch. 7: Communication in Personal Relationships Ch. 9: Communication in Organizations	- All Group Speech Formal Outlines due - Quiz Ch. 9: Communication in Organizations - Work on speech self-evaluations - Read Ch. 10 for Wed
	Wed	04/01	Group Speech - Day 2 (Upload PPT): Ch. 10: Communication and Culture Ch. 11: Media and Media Literacy	- Claim your topic on Forum - Quiz Ch. 10: Communication and Culture - Work on speech self-evaluations - Read Ch. 11 for Mon
W13	Mon	04/06	- MMS Review - Activities/Workshop/Q&A	- All Self-Evaluations for Group Speeches due - Team Contribution Assessment Form - Quiz Ch. 11: Media and Media Literacy - Purpose/Thesis/Preview (bring to class)
	Wed	04/08	Activities/Workshop/Q&A	Speech to Actuate Action Plan (bring to class)
W14	Mon	04/13	Activities/Workshop/Q&A	Work on your speeches
	Wed	04/15	Speech to Actuate (7-8 mins) - Day 1 (upload PPT)	- All Speech to Actuate Formal Outlines due - Work on speech self-evaluations
W15	Mon	04/20	Speech to Actuate (7-8 mins) - Day 2 (upload PPT)	Work on speech self-evaluations
	Wed	04/22	Speech to Actuate (7-8 mins) - Day 3 (upload PPT)	Work on speech self-evaluations
W16	Mon	04/27	Speech to Actuate (7-8 mins) - Day 4 (upload PPT)	Work on speech self-evaluations
	Wed	04/29	- Exam Prep - PRCA Post-Test	All Speech to Actuate Self-Evaluations due
W17	Mon	05/04	FINAL EXAM, 4:00 – 5:50 PM	